Lesson 1.3: Haiku, Sonnet, Opus

Claude Certified Associate – Foundations (CCAO-F) · Module 1: Platform & Model Foundations · Lesson 3 · 12:42

Description

Every chat starts with a choice most people never make on purpose: which model answers. Use the biggest model for everything and you wait longer and run through your usage faster. Use the smallest for everything and it eventually misses something. This lesson explains Claude's three model tiers, Haiku, Sonnet and Opus, and the four things that decide between them: speed, quality, cost and volume. It also covers effort, the second dial inside each model. You see where Anthropic publishes these trade-offs: the official exam guide, the Claude Platform Docs and the Help Center. Then one real job for this course runs on all three models in Claude Desktop, with the same prompt, the same document, a stopwatch, and a checklist decided before sending. The choice is made from the evidence. The lesson ends with the guide's Sample question 2 and one exam-style scenario, reasoned out loud.

Learning outcomes

By the end of this lesson you can:

1. Tell Haiku, Sonnet and Opus apart: what each tier trades in capability, speed and cost.
2. Match a model, and its effort, to a job's cost, speed, quality and volume.
3. Run the same real job on all three and pick the right one from the evidence.

Chapters

Time	Chapter
00:00	Preview and outcomes
00:37	Why it matters
01:09	The trade-off
02:34	Straight from the source
03:46	Hands-on: one job, three models
10:55	Exam angle
12:05	Recap and quick check

The three tiers

Version numbers change. The tiers stay. The versions named here are the ones current on 2026-10-04.

	Haiku (Haiku 4.5)	Sonnet (Sonnet 5.5)	Opus (Opus 5.5)
In one line	Small, fast, the cheapest to run	The balanced middle, and Anthropic's recommended default for everyday work	The most capable of the three, but slower and costlier
Claude Platform Docs, description	"The fastest model with near-frontier intelligence"	"The best combination of speed and intelligence"	"For long-running agentic coding and knowledge work"
Claude Platform Docs, comparative latency	Fastest	Fast	Moderate
API price per million input / output tokens	$1 / $5	$2 / $10	$4 / $20
Claude Desktop model menu	"Fastest for quick answers"	"Most efficient for simpler tasks"	"For complex work and everyday tasks"; on hover: "Opus draws down usage faster than Sonnet"
Thinking and effort in the app	No effort levels. Thinking is one "Extended" switch (off by default)	Effort Low, Medium (marked recommended), High, Extra, Max	Effort levels; Medium was marked recommended in our run
Who can use it on Claude.ai	Anyone	Anyone	Pro, Max, Team and Enterprise

What "cost" means depends on where you use Claude. In the Claude apps you don't pay per message. Cost is your plan's usage limits, and bigger models and higher effort use them faster. Through the API (for developers), cost is a price per token. The docs add that comparative latency is "relative to the current lineup" and that "actual latency depends on prompt length, output length, and thinking effort."

Effort: the second dial

Effort is how thoroughly a model works on each reply. In the Help Center's words: "Higher effort means more thorough responses, but they take longer and use more tokens, so you'll reach your usage limits faster." Low and Medium suit routine tasks and stretch your usage. High offers the best overall balance of quality and speed. Max is the most thorough option, for the deepest reasoning. In the app's menu, Max carries a warning: 5× or more usage. Anthropic's model guide adds: "Tuning effort is often a better lever than switching models." You can change the model, effort level or thinking setting at any point in a conversation, and the change applies from Claude's next response.

The rule and the map

This rule is the course's own, built from Anthropic's guidance (*Choosing the right model*, Option 1 "efficiency-first" and Option 2 "capability-first"). It is not an Anthropic document.

1. Start with the smallest tier that can clearly do the job.
2. Test it on your real task.
3. Step up only where quality falls short.

The job	Start with
Short, simple jobs at volume, where speed and cost matter most	Haiku
Everyday work	Sonnet
Complex reasoning, where being right outweighs the cost	Opus

Volume multiplies every gap. Run a job 500 times, and every delay and every bit of usage multiplies too. That pulls simple, high-volume work toward Haiku. A one-off job where accuracy is everything pulls the other way.

Key terms

- **Model tier:** Haiku, Sonnet or Opus, the size of Claude you pick, trading capability against speed and cost.
- **Latency:** how long you wait for the answer.
- **Token:** a small chunk of text a model reads or writes. API prices and usage are counted in tokens.
- **Usage limit:** your plan's allowance. Bigger models and more effort use it faster. On Pro and Max plans it resets every five hours, with a weekly limit as well.
- **Volume:** how many times a job runs. It multiplies every difference in time and cost.
- **Effort:** how thoroughly a model works on each reply, from Low to Max. Higher is more thorough, slower, and uses more of your limits.

What happened in the hands-on

Claude Desktop 2.9939.4 on Linux, Chat view, recorded on 2026-10-04 on a real account. There were three fresh chats, one per model, run in the order Haiku, Sonnet, Opus. Before the first message in each chat, Memory was switched off for that chat, and web search and the connected apps were switched off in the + menu, so only the attached document could inform the answer. Each model ran at the level the app recommends for it: Haiku 4.5 with Extended thinking off (the default), Sonnet 5.5 at Medium, and Opus 5.5 at Medium. Each chat got the same official exam guide PDF and the same prompt. The prompt was typed in chat 1, then pasted word for word with Ctrl+Shift+V in chats 2 and 3.

The job. This course needs two things: (1) a plain-English line for each of the guide's 30 task statements, for lesson cards (many short drafts, the volume job); and (2) a correct answer to the scoring question beginners ask (a judgment call, with a trap: 720 out of 1,000 looks like 72%, but it's a scaled score, and the guide gives no conversion to correct answers).

The check, decided before sending. Job 1: 30 lines in order, 10 words or fewer each, meaning kept. Job 2: no made-up pass count, and about 13 questions from Domain 2 (21% of 60 = 12.6), flagged as approximate.

Timings in our run. These are single runs on one day, measured from the recording frames, from pressing Enter. They are not a benchmark. Times vary with server load, prompt length and output length.

Model, setting	First reply text	Reply complete	What showed while waiting
Haiku 4.5 (Extended off)	2.5 s	8.4 s	No thinking step. The text started almost at once
Sonnet 5.5, Medium	8.0 s	12.4 s	A status word ("Reckoning"), then its step ("Tallying task statements across each guide domain"), and a one-line summary above the reply
Opus 5.5, Medium	35.0 s	43.6 s	Labelled thinking steps with a seconds counter. The counter read 19 s when the text began, so it counts only part of the wait

What each model produced (the full replies are in the student kit):

- **Haiku:** 30 lines in order, all within 8 words. But most lines are the guide's own wording with the specifics trimmed off: "3.2 Differentiate between Claude model types." and "3.3 Align model selection with task requirements." (no Haiku, Sonnet or Opus, and no cost, speed or quality). Job 2 (49 words): the exact number isn't stated, and Domain 2 is approximately 12–13 questions. That passes, but it's brief, and it never warns against the obvious guess. In a practice run before recording, Haiku did guess a pass count ("approximately 43–44 correct answers").

- **Sonnet:** 30 lines, all within 9 words, in plain English with the specifics kept: "3.2 Tell Haiku, Sonnet, and Opus apart." and "3.3 Match the model to your cost, speed, quality needs." Job 2 (71 words): the guide doesn't say; 720 is a scaled score, not a percentage, with no mapping to correct answers; Domain 2 is roughly 12–13 questions, and the weights are approximate. It added that domain percentages don't decide pass or fail.
- **Opus:** 30 lines, all within 10 words, specifics kept: "3.2 Tell the Haiku, Sonnet, and Opus models apart." and "3.3 Pick a model based on cost, speed, and quality." It opened with a true note: the guide doesn't number its task statements. Job 2 (70 words): named the tempting wrong answer ("don't assume it means 72% (about 43 questions)") and ruled it out; Domain 2 is roughly 12 or 13, and approximate.

One check against the source: the guide's own wording for 3.2 and 3.3 puts the models and the factors in brackets. Opus and Sonnet kept both. Haiku dropped exactly those words.

	Haiku 4.5	**Sonnet 5.5**	**Opus 5.5**
Job 1 · 30 lines, in order	✓	✓	✓
Job 1 · 10 words or fewer (longest line)	✓ (8)	✓ (9)	✓ (10)
Job 1 · specifics kept	dropped	✓	✓
Job 2 · no invented pass count	✓	✓	✓
Job 2 · about 13, flagged as approximate	✓	✓	✓
Job 2 · under 80 words	✓ (49)	✓ (71)	✓ (70)

The verdict, by the rule. Job 1: Haiku lost the specifics, so it didn't clearly pass. Step up one tier, to Sonnet. At real volume, the next test would be Haiku again with a sharper instruction. Job 2: all three avoided the trap in the recorded run, but Haiku had guessed in practice, and one clean answer isn't proof, so the scoring answer goes to Sonnet too. Opus was just as good here, but about 3.5 times slower than Sonnet in our run, at twice the API price. It earns its place when the reasoning gets harder.

The exam link

Domain 3, Product and Model Selection (12% of scored items), task statements 3.2 and 3.3 (our labels; quoted word for word from the guide): "Differentiate between Claude model types (Haiku, Sonnet, Opus)" and "Align model selection with task requirements (cost, speed, quality)". The guide's public Sample question 2 describes a high volume of short customer-reply drafts, where speed and cost matter more than deep reasoning. Its answer is a faster, lower-cost model suited to straightforward, high-volume tasks. Lesson 1.1 introduced the model decision, Lesson 1.2 covered the features decision, and Lesson 1.4 covers context.

The lesson's practice scenario (original, written for this course, not from the exam). A legal operations lead must review one 60-page supplier contract before Friday, and flag every clause whose liability terms contradict the company's standard terms. It's a one-off, and accuracy matters most. Which fits best? A: Haiku, fastest and cheapest. B: the most capable model, accepting slower, costlier replies. C: ask all three, and keep what two flag. D: split it across 20 Haiku chats. The answer is **B**. Read the dials: volume is one, and quality is everything. A optimizes the wrong dial. C triples the usage, and agreement isn't proof. D cuts apart clauses that must be read together. It's Anthropic's capability-first case ("Applications where accuracy outweighs cost considerations"). Higher effort fits too, and she still checks the flagged clauses.

Quick check

Before you move on, take this lesson's quick check. It's a few short questions and takes a couple of minutes. Module 1's quiz comes after Lesson 1.4. The exam-style question in this lesson, the quick checks, the module quizzes and the practice exams are all original, written for this course against the official blueprint. They are never copies of the real exam.

Sources (all checked 2026-10-04)

- **Anthropic, *Claude Certified Associate – Foundations Exam Guide*.** Version 1.0, effective July 2026. §5 (scaled score of 720 on 100–1,000), §6 Domain 3 task statements 3.2 and 3.3 (p. 5) and the domain weights, §8 Sample question 2 and its answer key (pp. 6–7), §9 (section-level percentages are not used to decide pass or fail). Official download: https://everpath-course-content.s3-accelerate.amazonaws.com/instructor/6nizmqk8tpzpfjvt6qmmav7rh/public/1783542847/Claude+Certified+Associate+%E2%80%93+Foun
- **Claude Platform Docs:**
  - *Models overview* (descriptions, comparative latency and its footnote, pricing row): https://platform.claude.com/docs/en/about-claude/models/overview
  - *Choosing the right model* (Option 1 efficiency-first, Option 2 capability-first, "Tuning effort is often a better lever than switching models", test with your actual prompts and data): https://platform.claude.com/docs/en/about-claude/models/choosing-a-model
  - *Pricing* (price per million tokens): https://platform.claude.com/docs/en/about-claude/pricing
  - *Effort*: https://platform.claude.com/docs/en/build-with-claude/effort
  - *Model deprecations* (Haiku 4.5 is active, retirement not sooner than October 15, 2026, on Anthropic's platforms): https://platform.claude.com/docs/en/about-claude/model-deprecations
- **Claude Help Center:**
  - *Change the model, effort, and thinking settings* (effort levels, the Extended switch, changing settings mid-conversation): https://support.claude.com/en/articles/8664678-change-the-model-effort-and-thinking-settings

    - *How do usage and length limits work?* (model choice and effort affect usage; all Claude surfaces share one limit): https://support.claude.com/en/articles/11647753-how-do-usage-and-length-limits-work
    - *Usage limit best practices*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/9797557-usage-limit-best-practices
    - *What is the Pro plan?*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/8325606-what-is-the-pro-plan
    - *What is the Max plan?*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/11049741-what-is-the-max-plan
    - *When should I use web search, extended thinking, and research?*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/11095361-when-should-i-use-web-search-extended-thinking-and-research
- **Claude Academy, Claude 101,** *Your first conversation with Claude* (Sonnet as the recommended default for everyday users): https://academy.claude.com/courses/claude-101/your-first-conversation-with-claude
- **Anthropic's model pages** (availability on Claude.ai): https://www.anthropic.com/claude/haiku · https://www.anthropic.com/claude/sonnet · https://www.anthropic.com/claude/opus
- **Anthropic's official CCAO-F prep course** (its troubleshooting course lists the wrong feature or model as a root cause when results fall short).
- **The app itself:** Claude Desktop 2.9939.4 on Linux, model menu and Effort submenu, observed 2026-10-04. Menus and labels can change between versions.

What you see in the lesson is a real account. The model menu is shown framed on the three models this course teaches. Settings → Account and Settings → Memory were never opened. For the recording, Opus's effort was set to the app's recommended Medium, and the connected apps were switched off; both were restored afterwards.